



A foldable Razr phone

Latest Motorola patent teases a Razr like flip phone with a foldable display.
<https://digit.in/feb19-7>



SSD with a heat sink

WD has started shipping gaming oriented WD Black SSDs with an optional heat sink and new firmware improvement. <https://digit.in/feb19-8>

Samsung Galaxy A9 (2018)

Playing the numbers game

It is an ongoing debate as to whether cramming more cameras in the phone counts as significant innovation, but Samsung's marketing machinery would want to convince you it does. The versatility the Galaxy A9 offers in smartphone photography was impressive in our review, but was the quality as good as you would expect from a high-end Galaxy phone?

Design

We received the Lemon Blue variant which was quite nice, however, the rear panel was smudged with fingerprints within the hour. The glass panel on the back reduces durability.

The Galaxy A9 stretches to over 6.3-inches and is not quite ergonomic to use. The fingerprint sensor on the back is easy to reach and is quite responsive too. There's bezels thick and thin, without a notch in sight.

Display

We registered peak brightness of 671 lux, while the minimum brightness fell down to 3 lux, which is dim enough to read comfortably in the dark. It's a well-optimised 18:9 panel and while it lacks the high pixel density that makes panels like the OnePlus 6T appear much sharper, it more than makes up for it in terms of colour reproduction. It's Widevine L1 certified, so you can stream videos from Netflix and Amazon Prime Video in FullHD resolution.

Performance and software

Even though it faces off against high-end flagships like the OnePlus 6T and the LG G7 ThinQ, the phone relies on a mid-range processor. The Snapdragon 660 has proven to be quite capable in handling daily tasks, but it's just not as seamlessly smooth as devices



Price
₹39,990



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powered by the Snapdragon 845 which are its primary competition. However, it scored higher than other Snapdragon 660 devices.

Throughout our usage, the Galaxy A9 didn't slow down or take a lot of time to launch apps and the likes. The Samsung Experience UI is well optimised but there are some bugs, especially with the camera app. Gaming on the Galaxy A9 is good enough, particularly for the vibrant screen, but the phone also has some heating issues, even on not so heavy games.

Camera

The four camera set up allows one to shoot wide-angle photos, zoomed in (2X optical) photos and portrait mode shots thanks to an additional depth sensor. However, the wide-angle lens does not have autofocus and the focus is fixed at infinity. The depth sensor makes no real sense as the telephoto and wide-angle lens can be enough for depth information.

The primary camera skips on any optical image stabilisation and as a result, low light photos aren't so nice. Also, indoor food shots showed some amounts of blurring. Samsung's noise reduction algorithms give the photos a warm tone.

The primary sensor also has a tendency to blow highlights, and the shadows come out darker. The ultra-wide angle camera offers a 12mm wide field of view and does not let you focus selectively. In the Pro mode, you cannot switch lenses. The ultra-wide angle lens also has high barrel distortion. The portrait mode on the Galaxy A9 is pretty good but the selfie camera on the Galaxy A9 isn't the best out there. Overall, the Galaxy A9's camera is simply playing the numbers game and trying to live on the hype of being the world's first quad-rear-camera phone.

Battery

The Galaxy A9 will give you around 6.5 hours of screen-on time, as revealed by the PCMark Work 2.0 battery test. The phone also doesn't support fast charging and topping up the battery to its full capacity takes more than 2 hours.

Verdict

All things considered, the Samsung Galaxy A9 is reliable enough for the performance but doesn't really justify the high price tag it comes with. The camera performance is not too great, as several glaring compromises take away heavily from the imaging experience. If you have ₹34,000 to spare, it's better to settle for a high-end flagship like the Asus Zenfone 5z or the Honor 10 or even pay a little extra and get the OnePlus 6T.

—Subhrojit Mallick

SPECIFICATIONS

PROCESSOR: Snapdragon 660 | DISPLAY SIZE: 15.95cm (6.3") | RESOLUTION: True FHD+ | PANEL: Super AMOLED | REAR CAMERA: 24MP (F1.7), 8MP (F2.4), 10MP (F2.4), 5MP (F2.2) | FRONT CAMERA: 24MP (F2.0) | RAM: 6GB/8GB | STORAGE: 128GB | EXPANDABLE: Up to 512GB | BATTERY: 3800 mAh

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